

had fought well, the crowd might want them to live. People waved their handkerchiefs, raised their thumbs, and called out, "Mitte!" ("Let them go!"). Then all eyes turned to see whether the giver of the games would agree. If they did, the gladiator was pardoned ... but next time might not be so lucky.

If the crowd thought the gladiator had put on a poor performance, they showed no mercy. As their thumbs turned down and cries of "*Iugula!*" ("Kill him!") rang across the arena, the

WEIRD WORLD

GLADIATORS WERE ADVERTISED BY THEIR "STAGE NAMES," SUCH AS PUGNAX ("QUARRELSOME ONE"), TIGRIS ("TIGER"), OR COLUMBUS ("DOVE"). FANS LOOKED FORWARD TO SEEING THE STAR FIGHTERS IN ACTION.

victim knew they were about to meet their end. Again, the games' sponsor had the last word. If they turned their thumb down, it was the signal for the doomed fighter to "take the iron" and be finished off. Their opponent executed them where they lay, and the people shouted, "*Habet!*" ("That's got them!").

IN THE FILM *SPARTACUS*, THE REBEL GLADIATOR (RIGHT), ARMED AS A THRACIAN, GRAPPLES WITH A NET-FIGHTER.

